Q. Who is best suited to succeed Modi as the BJP's prime ministerial candidate?



AMIT SHAH

29 29 26 27 28



YOGI ADITYANATH

26 25 19 25 26



NITIN GADKARI

15 16 13 15 7



RAJNATH SINGH

5 4 6 6 3



NIRMALA SITHARAMAN

1 1 2 3

Aug. '23 Feb. '24 Aug. '24
Feb. '25 Aug. '25
Rest, others & DK/ CS

Modi to rebalance India's foreign policy, hitherto characterised by a pronounced US tilt, and press the accelerator on what he calls NextGen reforms to boost the Indian economy.

At this critical juncture, encouragingly for Modi, INDIA TODAY's biannual Mood of the Nation (MOTN) survey reflects that the prime minister still has the backing and trust of the Indian electorate. As many as 58 per cent of respondents believe that Modi's performance as prime minister is 'good' or 'outstanding'. It may be a dip of 3.8 percentage points from the February 2025 MOTN poll, but matches his ratings soon after the 2024 general election. This result found reaffirmation when respondents were asked who they think is best suited to be India's next prime minister. Modi polls a steady 51.5 per cent endorsement compared to 51.2 per cent in February. The rating of his prime opponent—Opposition leader Rahul Gandhi—hovers at 24.7 per cent, which means Modi retains a significant 27 percentage point lead over him.

The ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) led by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), too, can draw some comfort from the latest MOTN. If a general election were to be held now, the NDA would secure 324 out of 543 seats in the Lok Sabha, 52 more than required for a simple majority. This is 19 seats less than the 343 seats in the February MOTN, but much higher than the 293 seats the NDA actually won in the 2024 general election. The NDA vote share of 46.7 per cent, too, is four percentage point higher than the 42.5 per cent in the Lok Sabha poll. These findings are bolstered by 52.4 per cent respondents saying they are either 'satisfied' or 'very satisfied' with the NDA government's performance, even if it is a 10 percentage point dip from the 62.1 per cent endorsement in February. It is something the NDA leadership needs to factor in as it navigates the turbulence ahead.

As for who will succeed Narendra Modi, Union home minister Amit Shah retains the lead over Yogi Adityanath, though the Uttar Pradesh chief minister is voted the best chief minister in the country by MOTN respondents.

The Warning Bells

Yet there is some cause for worry for the BJP too. While the party's individual vote share holds steady at 40.6 per cent, its seat tally is down 21 seats, from 281 in February to 260 now. This is also 12 seats short of a simple majority, though better than the actual deficit of 32 seats in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. What should worry the BJP, though, is that following its big wins in the Haryana and Maharashtra assembly polls last year (on its own in Haryana, and as part of the Mahayuti coalition in Maharashtra), the euphoria seems to be waning. The BJP's tally has also dropped in poll-bound Bihar and West Bengal. To add to the party's woes, its tally shows some decline in BJP-ruled states like Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan.

AS FOR WHO WILL SUCCEED NARENDRA MODI AS BJP'S PRIME MINISTERIAL CANDIDATE, UNION HOME MINISTER AMIT SHAH RETAINS HIS LEAD AS THE MOST PREFERRED CHOICE

For Modi, too, there are plenty of caveats. Normally, there is admiration for his bold tackling of crises, which translate into massive spikes in his popularity ratings in MOTN polls. For instance, the prime minister in his first term successfully countered Pakistan's attack on an Indian army camp in Uri in September 2016 with surgical strikes across the LoC, In November, in a bid to erase black money, he demonetised Rs 500 and Rs 1,000 notes in circulation. The twin feats cemented Modi's position as a strong and decisive leader, in the latter case despite the hardships of the aam aadmi. His ratings soared to 69 per cent in the January 2017 MOTN poll, from